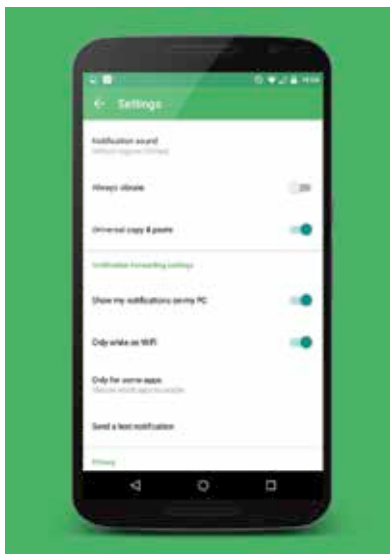




Flat design – toggle buttons and menu entries meant to make the most of flatness of the screen.

lends a sense of continuity to the user's experience.

Flat design draws from several ideologies. Its lack of embellishment speaks of minimalism, its bold and saturated colours hint at a strong influence of modernism, and it exhibits a dedication to practicality and usability typical of a utilitarian school of thought. In fact, flat design borrows certain specific features of skeuomorphism as well.

Less is more – minimalism

Minimalism entails a reduction of all design elements to their bare essentials. “Art begins with the getting rid of nature,” said Adolph Reinhardt, an artist whose minimalist work wouldn't look

out of place inside one of Google's own Material Design apps. In terms of UX/UI design, it means that the removal of distractions is the key to obtaining a pleasant interface. For example, a website made with flat design principles in mind will replace garish borders with whitespace padding, use subtle on-screen animations, and use geometrical shapes uniformly.

Minimalism has its own origins rooted in the early 20th century, with the emergence of the Dutch artistic movement known as “De Stijl” (Dutch for “The Style”). It advocated simplicity in shapes and colours- the artwork largely comprised of horizontal and vertical lines and a there was heavy preference for primary colours.

Guggenheim Museum's online collection of De Stijl artwork looks surprisingly similar to the tiled layout of a Windows phone – clearly, the underlying principles of design have come a full circle in a hundred years. The description provides great insight into the De Stijl approach. “The essential idea [...] was the creation of a universal aesthetic language,” says the Guggenheim blurb. Compare that with the goals that Google has laid out for their Material Design philosophy – “[...] to create a visual language [...]